490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 7 OF 26

# Isaac, Jacob, and Joseph

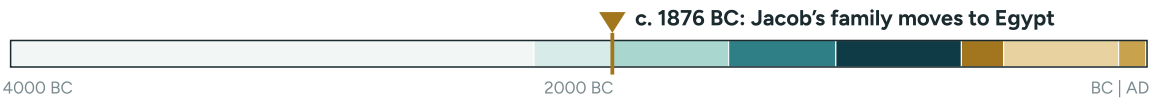
*Genesis 25–50*



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 7




## Introduction: A Family Like Ours

Most families have a drawer of photographs nobody shows company. The wedding where two brothers did not speak. The Christmas after the divorce. The picture with someone carefully cut out. If you want proof that the Bible is not a polished religious myth, read the second half of Genesis. It is the family album of Abraham's descendants, and every page has a crack in the frame.

A father who plays favorites. A mother who helps her son deceive his blind father. Twin brothers, one of whom wants to kill the other. A man who marries two sisters and loves one more than the other, so that their rivalry spills into twelve sons. Brothers who throw their younger brother into a pit and sell him as a slave, then lie to their father about it for twenty-two years. This is the family God chose to carry the promise to the whole world.

Last week God made three promises to Abraham: a land, a people, and a blessing for every family on earth. Genesis 25–50 follows those promises through three more generations, from about 2066 BC, when Isaac was born, to the 1800s BC, when Jacob's whole family moves down to Egypt. And it answers a question every one of us asks: can God keep his promises through people like this, through families like mine?

## The Word: Meant

> **Genesis 50:19–20** *"But Joseph said to them, 'Do not fear, for am I in the place of God? As for you, you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive, as they are today.'"*

חָשַׁב *(ḥashab, "to think, plan, reckon")*

*the same verb as Genesis 15:6, used twice in one sentence*

**חֲשַׁבְתֶּם (ḥashabtem)**

*"you meant"*

The brothers had a plan. They meant evil, and they were fully responsible for it.

+

**חֲשָׁבָה (ḥashabah)**

*"God meant it"*

God had a plan too, in the very same events. He meant them for good.

**Payoff:** Last week this verb meant "counted": God counted Abraham's faith as righteousness (Gen. 15:6). Here it means to plan or intend, and Joseph uses it twice about one event. The brothers planned. God planned. Their plan was evil, and God did not excuse it. His plan was good, and their evil could not stop it. Christians call this God's *providence*, and the Shorter Catechism defines it: "God's works of providence are his most holy, wise and powerful preserving and governing all his creatures, and all their actions" (WSC 11). All their actions, including the ones they mean for evil.

## Part One: Isaac and the Twins

The promise passed to Isaac, and the first thing we learn about his marriage is the same problem his parents had: "Isaac prayed to the LORD for his wife, because she was barren. And the LORD granted his prayer, and Rebekah his wife conceived" (Gen. 25:21). Again, the promised line depends on a gift only God can give.

Rebekah carried twins, and they fought inside her. When she asked the LORD why, he told her, "Two nations are in your womb… the older shall serve the younger" (25:23). Esau was born first. Jacob came out holding his brother's heel, and they named him Jacob, which sounds like the Hebrew for "heel" and came to mean one who grabs or supplants (25:26; 27:36; Hos. 12:3). It fit him. Years later, Esau came home starving, and Jacob traded him a bowl of stew for his birthright, the eldest son's double share of the inheritance (Deut. 21:17). "Thus Esau despised his birthright" (25:34). Hebrews calls him "unholy like Esau, who sold his birthright for a single meal" (Heb. 12:16).

Why did God choose Jacob, the younger and the grasper? Paul answers in Romans 9. Before the twins were born, while they "had done nothing either good or bad," God said the older would serve the younger, "in order that God's purpose of election might continue, not because of works but because of him who calls" (Rom. 9:11–12). Paul then quotes the prophet Malachi: "Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated" (Rom. 9:13). In Bible language, love and hate set side by side like this are words of choosing: God set his saving love on Jacob and passed Esau by. (Jesus uses a similar pairing in Luke 14:26, where "hate" means to love less by comparison.) God's choice of Jacob did not rest on anything in Jacob. That is what Paul calls *election*: God choosing his people in Christ, by grace alone, "before the foundation of the world"

(Eph. 1:4). The Westminster Confession says he chose them "out of his mere free grace and love, without any foresight of faith, or good works" (WCF 3.5). God did not choose Jacob because he saw ahead of time that Jacob would believe. God's choice is the reason Jacob believed at all.

If that sounds unfair, Paul heard the objection coming: "Is there injustice on God's part? By no means!" (Rom. 9:14). No one is owed mercy. When God passes someone by, he leaves them to what their own sin deserves. Esau's descendants became the nation of Edom (Gen. 25:30), and the prophets announce judgment on Edom for its own violence against Israel (Obad. 10). When God chooses someone, he gives what no one deserves. If God chose people for their goodness, Jacob would never have been chosen. Neither would you.

## Part Two: Jacob the Grasper

Jacob kept grasping. When their father Isaac was old and blind, Rebekah helped Jacob dress in goatskins and his brother's clothes so Isaac would bless him instead of Esau. Jacob lied to his father's face: "I am Esau your firstborn" (27:19). He got the blessing, and Esau swore to kill him, so Jacob fled north to his uncle Laban in Haran, the same region Abraham had left.

On the first night of his escape, alone, with a stone for a pillow, Jacob had a dream. "There was a ladder set up on the earth, and the top of it reached to heaven. And behold, the angels of God were ascending and descending on it!" (28:12). And the LORD stood above it and gave this liar and runaway the very promises he had given Abraham: the land, offspring like the dust of the earth, and "in you and your offspring shall all the families of the earth be blessed" (28:14). Then God added something personal: "Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go, and will bring you back to this land" (28:15). Jacob had not repented. He had not even asked. God simply came to him in grace.

Jacob woke up shaken: "This is none other than the house of God, and this is the gate of heaven" (28:17). He named the place Bethel, which means "house of God." But notice how he answers. He makes a bargain: "If God will be with me… then the LORD shall be my God" (28:20–21). Even after a vision of heaven, Jacob is still negotiating. God would spend twenty years wearing that out of him.

In Haran, Jacob the deceiver was deceived. He worked seven years for Laban's younger daughter Rachel, whom he loved, and on the wedding night Laban gave him the older sister, Leah, instead. Jacob married both and worked seven more years. The rivalry between the two sisters and their servants, Bilhah and Zilpah, produced eleven sons in Haran and a twelfth, Benjamin, after they left. Their families became the twelve tribes of Israel. (A tribe is a large clan descended from one ancestor.)

Twenty years later, Jacob headed home with his family and flocks, terrified of meeting Esau. The night before, alone by the river Jabbok, "a man wrestled with him until the breaking of the day" (32:24). When the man could not overcome Jacob, he touched his hip and put it out of joint. Jacob, crippled, would not let go: "I will not let you go unless you bless me." And the man asked his name. The last time someone asked Jacob his name, he lied and said, "Esau." Now he says the truth: "Jacob." Grasper. And the man renames him: "Your name shall no longer be called Jacob, but Israel, for you have striven with God and

with men, and have prevailed" (32:26–28). Jacob walked away limping and blessed, saying, "I have seen God face to face, and yet my life has been delivered" (32:30). Who was this man? Jacob says he saw God face to face, and the prophet Hosea calls him "the angel": "he strove with God. He strove with the angel and prevailed; he wept and sought his favor" (Hos. 12:3–4). Many readers take him to be the same angel of the LORD we met on Moriah, who speaks as God himself. Jacob "prevailed" with a dislocated hip. One touch had crippled him, and all he could do was weep and hold on until God blessed him. The nation of Israel takes its name from this night.

## Part Three: Joseph

Of all his sons, Jacob loved Joseph most, the first son of his beloved Rachel. He gave him a special robe, and his brothers "hated him and could not speak peacefully to him" (37:4). Joseph did not help matters. At seventeen he told his brothers about his dreams, in which they all bowed down to him. The favoritism Jacob had suffered from his own father, he now passed on to his sons.



*"They drew Joseph up and lifted him out of the pit, and sold him to the Ishmaelites for twenty shekels of silver" (Gen. 37:28).*

When Jacob sent Joseph to check on his brothers in the fields, they saw him coming and plotted to kill him. They threw him into an empty cistern. Then Judah had another idea: "What profit is it if we kill our brother and conceal his blood? Come, let us sell him" (37:26–27). So they sold him to passing traders for twenty shekels of silver. (Genesis calls them both Ishmaelites and Midianites, names that overlapped for

desert caravan peoples; compare Judg. 8:24.) They dipped his robe in goat's blood and let their father believe a wild animal had torn him apart. Notice the irony. Years before, Jacob had deceived his own father with goatskins. Now his sons deceive him with goat's blood.

Right after Joseph is sold, Genesis stops to tell an ugly story about Judah (Gen. 38). He left his brothers, married a Canaanite woman, and had three sons. The first two were wicked, and the LORD put them to death. Judah promised his third son to Tamar, the oldest son's widow, and then quietly broke the promise. So Tamar sat by the road dressed as a prostitute, and Judah slept with her, leaving his seal, cord, and staff as a pledge of payment. Three months later he heard his daughter-in-law was pregnant and ordered her burned. She sent him the pledge: "By the man to whom these belong, I am pregnant" (38:25). And Judah confessed: "She is more righteous than I" (38:26). Tamar bore twins, and one of them, Perez, became the ancestor of King David. Matthew writes her into the first lines of Jesus' family tree: "Judah the father of Perez and Zerah by Tamar" (Matt. 1:3). That confession on the road is where the Judah of chapter 44 begins.

Joseph was taken to Egypt and sold as a slave to an officer named Potiphar. And here a sentence appears that runs like a refrain through the next chapters: "The LORD was with Joseph" (39:2). He rose to run Potiphar's whole household. Then Potiphar's wife tried to seduce him, and when he refused, she accused him of attacking her, and he was thrown into prison. "But the LORD was with Joseph and showed him steadfast love" (39:21). Joseph did right and suffered for it. For at least two more years he sat in prison, forgotten by the people he had helped (40:23; 41:1).



*"Can we find a man like this, in whom is the Spirit of God?" (Gen. 41:38).*

Then Pharaoh had two dreams that no one could interpret, and someone remembered the Hebrew prisoner. Joseph told Pharaoh that God was warning of seven years of plenty followed by seven years of famine. Pharaoh was so impressed that he put Joseph in charge of all Egypt: “See, I have set you over all the land of Egypt” (41:41). Joseph was thirty years old (41:46). Thirteen years after the pit, the slave was second only to Pharaoh (41:40).

When the famine came, it struck Canaan too, and Jacob sent ten of his sons to Egypt to buy grain. They bowed before the governor without knowing who he was. Joseph’s dreams had come true. He tested them. He held one brother in prison and demanded they bring back Benjamin, the youngest, Rachel’s other son and now their father’s favorite. Then Joseph arranged for Benjamin to be accused of theft and said Benjamin would have to stay as his slave.

The turning point of the whole story belongs to Judah. Judah, the brother who had once suggested selling Joseph for silver, stepped forward and begged: “Please let your servant remain instead of the boy as a servant to my lord, and let the boy go back with his brothers. For how can I go back to my father if the boy is not with me?” (44:33–34). The man who once sold a brother into slavery now offered himself as a slave in his brother’s place. God had changed Judah.



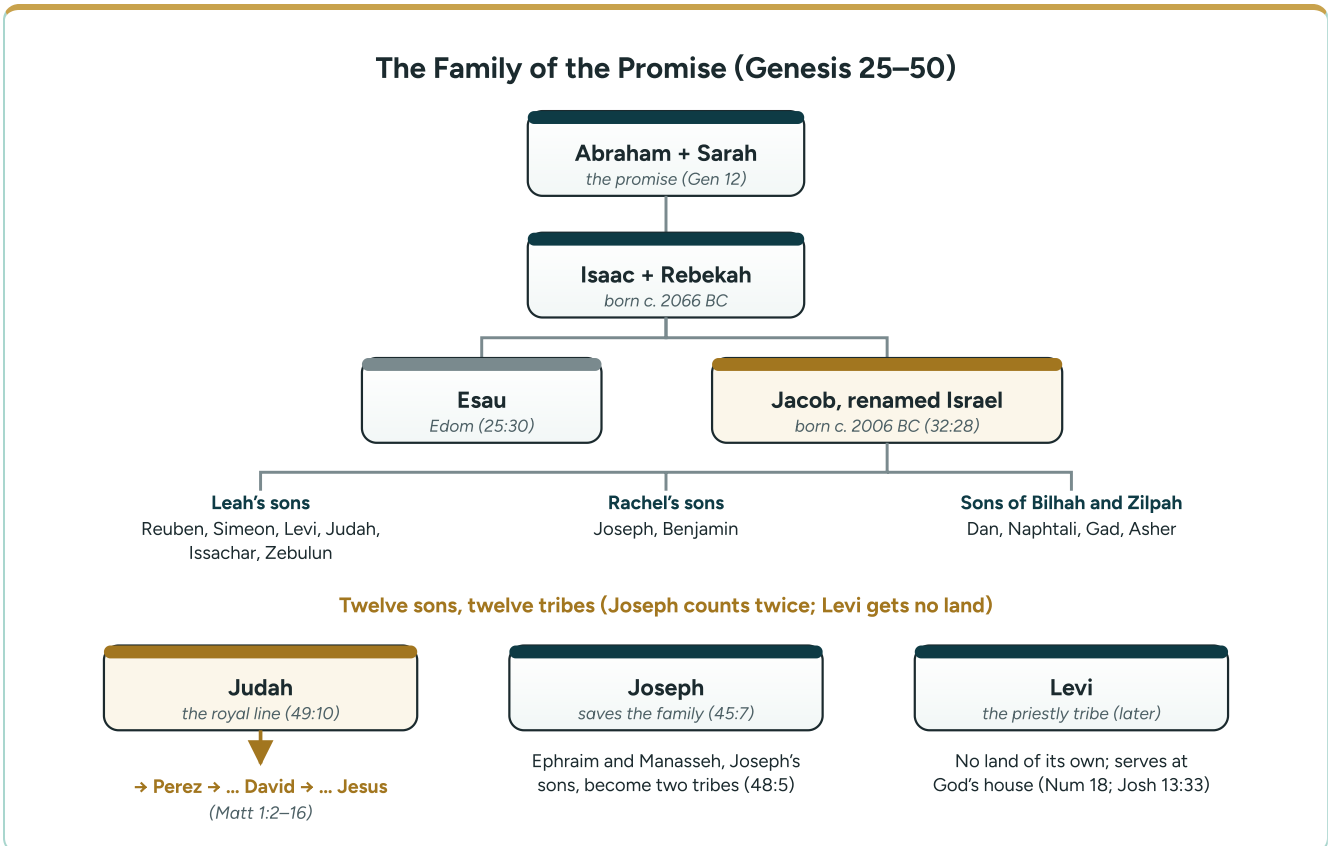
*“I am your brother, Joseph, whom you sold into Egypt” (Gen. 45:4).*

Joseph could not hold back any longer. He sent everyone else out and wept so loudly the Egyptians heard it. “I am Joseph!” His brothers were terrified. But Joseph said, “Come near to me, please… I am your brother, Joseph, whom you sold into Egypt. And now do not be distressed or angry with yourselves because you sold me here, for God sent me before you to preserve life” (45:3–5). He brought the whole family down to Egypt. The household of Jacob, numbered at seventy with Joseph and his sons (46:27),

was saved from the famine. (Stephen says seventy-five in Acts 7:14, following the Greek Old Testament, which counts more of Joseph's descendants.) Jacob saw the son he thought was dead. He would live his last seventeen years in Egypt and die there.

Near the end, Joseph brought his two sons, Manasseh and Ephraim, to his dying father. Jacob claimed them as his own: "Ephraim and Manasseh shall be mine, as Reuben and Simeon are" (48:5). That is why the Bible later counts two tribes from Joseph, and why the count still comes to twelve when Levi, the priestly tribe, receives no land of its own. Joseph placed the boys so Jacob's right hand, the hand of the greater blessing, would rest on Manasseh, the firstborn. Jacob crossed his hands and laid his right hand on Ephraim. Joseph tried to move it, and the old man refused: "I know, my son, I know… his younger brother shall be greater than he" (48:19). The grasper who once stole a blessing now gives one away, and like God at the twins' birth, he sets the younger ahead of the older. Hebrews remembers this moment as an act of faith (Heb. 11:21).

Before he died, Jacob blessed his sons, and he gave Judah a promise that reaches all the way to the end of the Bible: "The scepter shall not depart from Judah, nor the ruler's staff from between his feet… and to him shall be the obedience of the peoples" (49:10). (A scepter is the staff a king holds as the sign of his rule.) A king would come from Judah. Israel's great king David would come from Judah's line, and so would Jesus (Matt. 1:2–16).

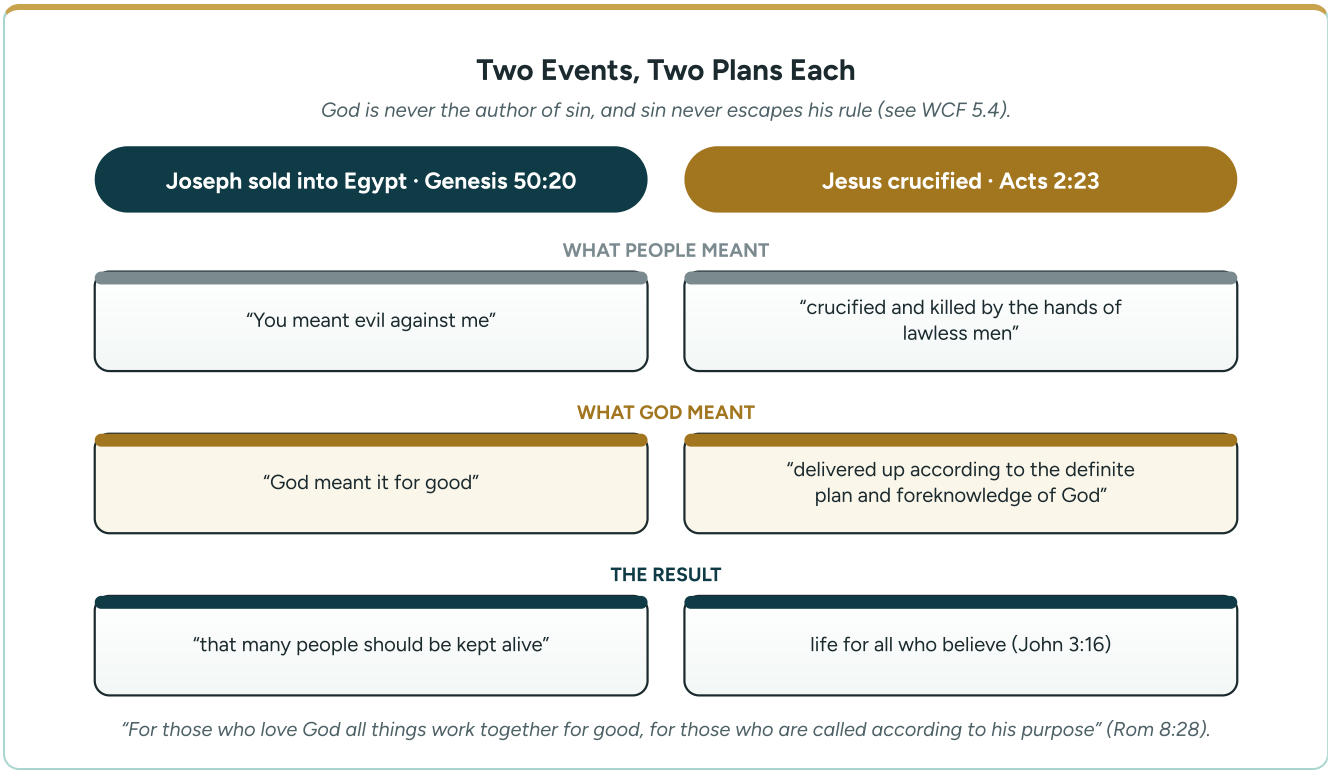


## Part Four: You Meant It for Evil, God Meant It for Good

After Jacob died, the brothers panicked. Surely now Joseph would pay them back. They sent a message begging forgiveness and came and fell down before him: "Behold, we are your servants." And Joseph wept, and said the sentence this whole story has been building toward: "Do not fear, for am I in the place of God? As for you, you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive, as they are today" (50:19–20).

Joseph held two things together that we usually pull apart. First, the brothers were guilty. He did not say, "It was all God's plan, so it's fine." They meant evil, and they did evil. Second, God was in control of every step. The pit, the slave caravan, the false accusation, the forgotten years in prison were all woven into God's plan to save thousands of lives, including the very family that had sold him.

The Westminster Confession says it with great care. God's providence reaches "even to the first fall, and all other sins of angels and men," not by merely allowing them, but by "bounding" and "ordering, and governing of them… to his own holy ends," and yet "the sinfulness thereof proceedeth only from the creature, and not from God, who, being most holy and righteous, neither is nor can be the author or approver of sin" (WCF 5.4).




This is one of the most practical truths in the Bible. Paul puts it in a single sentence: "And we know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose" (Rom. 8:28). That does not mean every bad thing is secretly good. Joseph's brothers did evil. It

means that God, who governs all things, will not let the evil done to his people have the last word. He will weave even that into good. And Paul tells us what that good is in the very next verse: to be "conformed to the image of his Son" (Rom. 8:29).

And notice what made Joseph able to forgive. "Am I in the place of God?" Joseph did not need to be the judge, because God already was. He did not need revenge to make the story come out right, because God had already written the ending. Forgiveness starts there, with trusting that God is God and you are not, and it never asks you to pretend the wound did not happen. For a Christian it goes one layer deeper: we forgive because we have been forgiven a debt we could never pay (Matt. 18:21–35; Eph. 4:32). In *Seventy Times Seven* I called Lamech's song, from Lesson 5, the score-keeping heart fully grown. Joseph held the ledger and had the power to collect, and he tore it up: "I will provide for you and your little ones" (50:21).

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE At Bethel, Jacob saw a ladder joining earth and heaven and said, "This is none other than the house of God, and this is the gate of heaven" (Gen. 28:17). Jesus told Nathanael, and through him all his disciples, "you will see heaven opened, and the angels of God ascending and descending on the Son of Man" (John 1:51). Jesus is Jacob's ladder, the living meeting place of God and man. And over and over in Joseph's story, the line returns: "The LORD was with Joseph."

THE LAMB Judah offered himself "instead of the boy" (Gen. 44:33), a substitute again, like the ram "instead of his son" on Moriah. And Jacob's blessing called Judah "a lion's cub" (49:9). In heaven, John is told to look at "the Lion of the tribe of Judah," and when he looks, he sees "a Lamb standing, as though it had been slain" (Rev. 5:5–6). The Lion from Judah wins by being the Lamb.

CORE DOCTRINE 7 OF 26

## The Providence of God

God not only made the world; he holds it together and governs everything in it, from kings and nations to sparrows and hairs on our heads. He works even through human sin and suffering for his good purposes, without ever doing evil himself.

KEY VERSES

Genesis 50:20; Proverbs 16:9; Matthew 10:29–31; Romans 8:28

WHAT THE CHURCH CONFESSES

*"God's works of providence are, his most holy, wise, and powerful preserving and governing all his creatures, and all their actions."* (Westminster Shorter Catechism 11)

WHY IT MATTERS

Nothing in your life is random. The God who used Joseph's pit and prison is still at work, and for those who love him, he works all things together for good.

## The Turn: The Brother Who Saves

Read Joseph's story again and you will hear echoes of another story. The New Testament never says outright that Joseph was a picture of Jesus, but when Stephen retells Israel's history, Joseph is the first in a line of deliverers whom God's people rejected, a line Stephen says ends with "the Righteous One" (Acts 7:9–10, 35, 52): "the patriarchs, jealous of Joseph, sold him into Egypt; but God was with him and rescued him." Hold the parallels loosely, but they are there.

Joseph was the beloved son of his father, rejected by his own brothers, sold for pieces of silver, falsely accused, and locked in the king's prison (39:20). He went down into the pit and was raised up to be second only to the king, and men cried out before him, "Bow the knee!" (41:43). And from that place of power he did not take revenge. He forgave the very brothers who betrayed him, and he became the means by which they were saved.

Jesus came "to his own, and his own people did not receive him" (John 1:11). He was betrayed for thirty pieces of silver, falsely accused, and crucified between criminals. And Peter, preaching in Jerusalem, said the most Joseph-like sentence in the New Testament: "this Jesus, delivered up according to the definite plan and foreknowledge of God, you crucified and killed by the hands of lawless men" (Acts 2:23). You meant it for evil. God meant it for good. The worst thing human beings ever did, killing the Son of God, was the very thing God used to save us. And then God raised him up and seated him at his right hand.

The brothers came to Joseph afraid, offering to be his slaves. He said, "Do not fear… I will provide for you." That is exactly how the risen Jesus receives sinners who come to him. You do not have to bargain like Jacob at Bethel. You do not have to grasp. You can come the way Jacob finally came at the river: limping, honest about your name, holding on. Turn from your sin and trust the Brother who is "not ashamed to call them brothers" (Heb. 2:11), who "suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous, that he might bring us to God" (1 Pet. 3:18), and who was raised again. He will not pay you back, because he took the payment himself. He has already provided everything you need.

### Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read the story in big pieces.** Read Genesis 37–41, 42–45, and 46–50 over three days. It reads like a novel. Let it.

2. **Find your "but God."** Think of something done against you that still hurts. Pray Genesis 50:20 over it: they meant it for evil, but God can mean it for good.

3. **Stop bargaining.** Where are you still praying "If God will… then I will" like Jacob at Bethel? Trade the bargain for trust.

4. **Break a family pattern.** Jacob passed favoritism to his sons. Name one unhealthy pattern you received, and ask God to let it end with you.

5. **Leave the judging to God.** When you are tempted to pay someone back, say Joseph's words to yourself: "Am I in the place of God?"

6 **Memorize Genesis 50:20.** “As for you, you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good.”

**Before Lesson 8:** *Read Exodus 1–3, 12, and 14–15. Lesson 8 opens Unit 3: four hundred years later, Abraham’s family are slaves in Egypt, and God hears their cry.*

## For Discussion

1. Why do you think God chose to carry his promise through such a broken family? What encouragement does that give you?
2. Romans 9 says God chose Jacob “not because of works but because of him who calls.” How does that make you feel? Why is it good news?
3. At Jabbok, Jacob finally told the truth about his name. Why does honesty about who we are matter so much in coming to God?
4. Judah went from selling a brother to offering himself in his brother’s place. What changed him? Where have you seen God change someone like that?
5. “You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good.” How does that sentence hold both human guilt and God’s control together?
6. Joseph asked, “Am I in the place of God?” How does trusting God’s judgment free us to forgive?
7. Which parallel between Joseph and Jesus stands out most to you, and why?

## Sources & For Further Study

- Westminster Shorter Catechism (1647), Q. 11 (providence). Westminster Confession of Faith (1646), 3.5 (election) and 5.4 (providence and sin).
- On חָשַׁב in Genesis 50:20: Brown, Driver, and Briggs, *Hebrew and English Lexicon*; Koehler and Baumgartner, *HALOT*, s.v.
- On Hosea 12:3–4 and the wrestler at Jabbok: John Calvin, *Commentary on Hosea*, on 12:3–4. David S. Jones, *Seventy Times Seven: On the God Who Forgives Past All Counting*, chapters 8 and 18.
- For further reading: Derek Kidner, *Genesis* (Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries); John Calvin, *Commentary on Genesis*, on chapters 28, 32, and 45–50; Timothy Keller, *Walking with God through Pain and Suffering*; Jerry Bridges, *Trusting God*.




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